



Asia

Lebanon

The cedar tree is the national symbol of Lebanon.

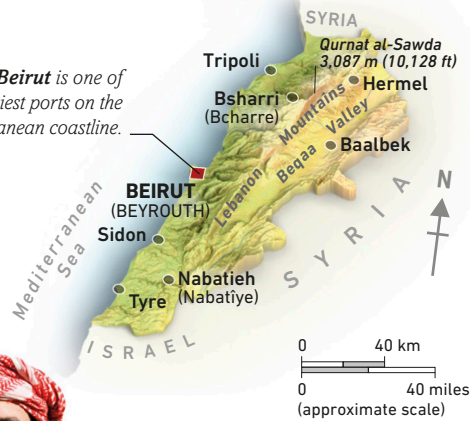
Beirut is one of the busiest ports on the Mediterranean coastline.

Ancient wine

Lebanon's Bekaa Valley is one of the world's oldest wine-making regions. Its wine has been famous since biblical times, almost 3,000 years ago, and has enjoyed a revival in recent years.



A farmer holds a freshly harvested basket of grapes.



Meaty treat

The national dish is kibbeh—a mix of meat, onions, spices, herbs, and bulgur wheat that is fried until crispy.

Pigeon Rocks
This pair of giant limestone rocks stands in the sea off the coast of Beirut, where they are a popular landmark for locals and visitors.



- 4,015 sq miles (10,400 sq km)
- 5.5 million
- Beirut
- Arabic, French, Armenian, Assyrian

This **Mediterranean** country has been a **trading center** for thousands of years. Lebanon's population is unique in the Middle East for its almost even mix of **Muslim** and **non-Muslim faith groups**, including **Maronite Christians**, and **Druze**.



Israel

More than 5 million Palestinians live in the West Bank and Gaza.

Tree-planting festival

The Jewish "New Year for Trees" is when fruit trees are planted and Jews eat the fruit of Israel, such as grapes, figs, dates, and pomegranates.



- 8,470 sq miles (21,937 sq km)
- 8.7 million
- Jerusalem
- Hebrew, Arabic, other languages (+6)

Israel was **created** in 1948 as a homeland for the **Jewish people**. The state has been in conflict with the **displaced Palestinians**, now living in the **West Bank** and **Gaza**, ever since.



Currently, the United Nations does not recognize Jerusalem as the capital of Israel.

Vibrant Tel Aviv

A lively city on the Mediterranean Sea, Tel Aviv has engulfed the old port of Yafo. It is known for its modern buildings and popular beaches.



Ancient Jerusalem

Dating back to 2000 BCE, the Old City is considered holy in Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. Its sacred sites include the Jewish Western Wall and the Islamic Dome of the Rock shrine.

